

Anxiety, fear and panic

Most people feel anxious or scared sometimes, but if it's affecting your life there are things you can try that may help. Support is also available if you're finding it hard to cope with anxiety, fear or panic.

Get urgent help

Support is available if you or someone you know is having a mental health crisis or emergency, no matter what you're going through.

Find out where to get urgent help for mental health (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/where-to-get-urgent-help-for-mental-health/)

Symptoms of anxiety

Anxiety can cause many different symptoms. It might affect how you feel physically, mentally and how you behave.

It's not always easy to recognise when anxiety is the reason you're feeling or acting differently.

[Physical symptoms](#)

- faster, irregular or more noticeable heartbeat
- feeling light-headed and dizzy
- headaches
- chest pains
- loss of appetite
- indigestion, stomach cramps, bloating and feeling sick (nausea)
- constipation or diarrhoea
- sweating
- breathlessness
- feeling hot
- shaking

[Mental symptoms](#)

- feeling tense or nervous
- being unable to relax
- worrying about the past or future
- feeling tearful
- not being able to sleep
- difficulty concentrating
- fear of the worst happening
- intrusive traumatic memories
- obsessive thoughts

[Changes in behaviour](#)

- not being able to enjoy your leisure time
- difficulty looking after yourself
- struggling to form or maintain relationships
- worried about trying new things
- avoiding places and situations that create anxiety
- compulsive behaviour, such as constantly checking things

Symptoms of a panic attack

If you experience sudden, intense anxiety and fear, it might be the symptoms of a panic attack. Other symptoms may include:

- a racing heartbeat
- feeling faint, dizzy or light-headed
- feeling that you're losing control
- sweating, trembling or shaking
- shortness of breath or breathing very quickly
- a tingling in your fingers or lips
- feeling sick (nausea)

A panic attack usually lasts 5 to 20 minutes. They can be frightening, but they're not dangerous and should not harm you.

Things you can try to help with anxiety, fear and panic

Do

- ✓ try talking about your feelings to a friend, family member, health professional or counsellor
- ✓ regular exercise such as running, walking, swimming and yoga – this can help you relax
- ✓ eat a healthy diet with regular meals to keep your energy levels stable
- ✓ use calming breathing exercises or try meditation
- ✓ listen to free mental wellbeing audio guides (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/mental-wellbeing-audio-guides/)

Don't

- ✗ do not try to do everything at once – set small targets that you can easily achieve
- ✗ do not focus on the things you cannot change – focus your time and energy into helping yourself feel better
- ✗ do not avoid situations that make you anxious – try slowly building up time spent in worrying situations to gradually reduce anxiety
- ✗ try not to tell yourself that you're alone – most people experience anxiety or fear at some point in their life
- ✗ try not to use alcohol, cigarettes, gambling or drugs to relieve anxiety as these can all contribute to poor mental health

Audio: How to cope with anxiety – a relaxation technique

In this audio guide, a doctor explains how you can take control of anxiety.



Help and support for anxiety, fear and panic

Learning more about anxiety, fear and panic can be useful as it may help you better manage your feelings. You may also find it helpful to get support from other people with similar experiences.

Mind

Information and support for anyone concerned about their mental health.

- Website: www.mind.org.uk (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/>)
- How to manage anxiety and worry (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/anxiety-problems/how-to-manage-anxiety-and-worry/>)
- Panic attacks (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/panic-attacks/>)
- How to find a support group (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/guides-to-support-and-services/peer-support-groups/how-to-find-a-support-group/>)

Samaritans

You can contact Samaritans (Link: <https://www.samaritans.org/how-we-can-help/contact-samaritan/>) by calling 116 123 (Link: Tel: 116 123) if you need someone to talk to at any time, day or night.

Every Mind Matters

Every Mind Matters is a NHS online service that can give you practical advice on how to reduce your anxiety, manage stress and worry, and boost your mental wellbeing.

- Website: www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters>)
- Managing anxiety (Every Mind Matters) (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters/mental-health-issues/anxiety/>)

- Self-help CBT techniques (Every Mind Matters) (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters/mental-wellbeing-tips/self-help-cbt-techniques/>)

When and where to get medical help

If you're struggling to cope with feelings of anxiety, fear and panic and the things you're doing are not helping, then you may need medical help.

See a GP if:

- you're struggling to cope with anxiety, fear or panic
- things you're trying yourself are not helping
- you would prefer to get a referral to an NHS talking therapies service from a GP

Other ways to get help

If you're 18 or over (or 16 or over in some areas), you can refer yourself directly to an NHS talking therapies service without talking to a GP.



Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/find-nhs-talking-therapies-for-anxiety-and-depression/)

If you're under 18, find out more about mental health support for children and young people (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/children-and-young-adults/mental-health-support/).

Causes of anxiety, fear and panic

There are many different causes of anxiety, fear or panic and it's different for everyone.

When you're feeling anxious or scared, your body releases stress hormones, such as adrenaline and cortisol.

This can be helpful in some situations, but it might also cause physical symptoms such as an increased heart rate and increased sweating. In some people, it might cause a panic attack.

Regular anxiety, fear or panic can also be the main symptom of several health conditions. Do not self-diagnose – speak to a GP if you're worried about how you're feeling.

Identifying the cause

If you know what's causing anxiety, fear or panic, it might be easier to find ways to manage it.

Some examples of possible causes include:

- work – feeling pressure at work, unemployment or retirement
- family – relationship difficulties, divorce or caring for someone (Link: www.nhs.uk/social-care-and-support/support-and-benefits-for-carers/)
- financial problems – unexpected bills or borrowing money
- health – illness, injury or losing someone (bereavement) (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/grief-bereavement-loss/)
- difficult past experiences – bullying, abuse or neglect

Even significant life events such as buying a house, having a baby or planning a wedding could lead to feelings of stress and anxiety.

You might find it hard to explain to people why you feel this way, but talking to someone could help you find a solution.

Conditions related to anxiety, fear and panic

Symptoms	Possible cause
Feelings of anxiety that will not go away, anxiety is affecting your life	Generalised anxiety disorder (GAD) (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/conditions/generalised-anxiety-disorder-gad/)
Overwhelming fear of something specific like an object, place or animal	Phobias (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/conditions/phobias/)
Regularly experiencing panic attacks	Panic disorder (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/conditions/panic-disorder/)
Often reliving traumatic past experiences, nightmares and flashbacks	PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/conditions/ptsd-post-traumatic-stress-disorder/)

More in Feelings and symptoms (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/)

Stress (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/stress/>)

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Low mood, sadness and depression (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/low-mood-sadness-depression/>)

Feeling lonely (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/feeling-lonely/>)

Grief after bereavement or loss (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/grief-bereavement-loss/>)

Anger (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/anger/>)

Hallucinations and hearing voices (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/feelings-and-symptoms/hallucinations-hearing-voices/>)

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